Agile Software Development

Rapid software development

- Rapid development and delivery are now often the most important requirement for software systems
  - Businesses operate in a fast –changing requirement and it is practically impossible to produce a set of stable software requirements
  - Software has to evolve quickly to reflect changing business needs.
- Rapid software development
  - Specification, design and implementation are inter-leaved
  - System is developed as a series of versions with stakeholders involved in version evaluation
  - User interfaces are often developed using an IDE and graphical toolset.

Agile methods

- Dissatisfaction with the overheads involved in software design methods of the 1980s and 1990s led to the creation of agile methods. These methods:
  - Focus on the code rather than the design
  - Are based on an iterative approach to software development
  - Are intended to deliver working software quickly and evolve this quickly to meet changing requirements.
- The aim of agile methods is to reduce overheads in the software process (e.g., by limiting documentation) and to be able to respond quickly to changing requirements without excessive rework.

Agile manifesto

- *We are uncovering better ways of developing software by doing it and helping others do it. Through this work we have come to value:*
  - *Individuals and interactions over processes and tools*
    Working software over comprehensive documentation
    Customer collaboration over contract negotiation
    Responding to change over following a plan
- *That is, while there is value in the items on the right, we value the items on the left more.*

The principles of agile methods

Principle	Description
Customer involvement	Customers should be closely involved throughout the development process. Their role is provide and prioritize new system requirements and to evaluate the iterations of the system.
Incremental delivery	The software is developed in increments with the customer specifying the requirements to be included in each increment.
People not process	The skills of the development team should be recognized and exploited. Team members should be left to develop their own ways of working without prescriptive processes.
Embrace change	Expect the system requirements to change and so design the system to accommodate these changes.
Maintain simplicity	Focus on simplicity in both the software being developed and in the development process. Wherever possible, actively work to eliminate complexity from the system.

Agile method applicability

- Product development where a software company is developing a small or medium-sized product for sale.
- Custom system development within an organization, where there is a clear commitment from the customer to become involved in the development process and where there are not a lot of external rules and regulations that affect the software.
- Because of their focus on small, tightly-integrated teams, there are problems in scaling agile methods to large systems.

Problems with agile methods

- It can be difficult to keep the interest of customers who are involved in the process.
- Team members may be unsuited to the intense involvement that characterizes agile methods.
- Prioritizing changes can be difficult where there are multiple stakeholders.
- Maintaining simplicity requires extra work.
- Contracts may be a problem as with other approaches to iterative development.

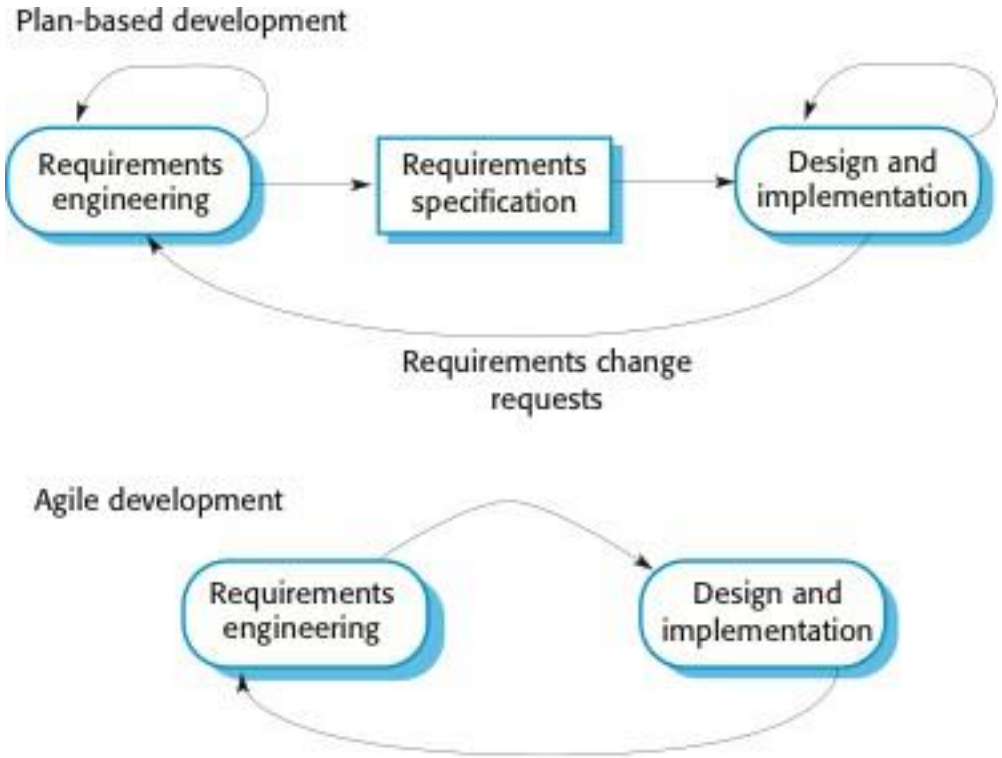
Agile methods and software maintenance

- Most organizations spend more on maintaining existing software than they do on new software development. So, if agile methods are to be successful, they have to support maintenance as well as original development.
- Two key issues:
  - Are systems that are developed using an agile approach maintainable, given the emphasis in the development process of minimizing formal documentation?
  - Can agile methods be used effectively for evolving a system in response to customer change requests?
- Problems may arise if original development team cannot be maintained.

Plan-driven and agile development

- Plan-driven development
  - A plan-driven approach to software engineering is based around separate development stages with the outputs to be produced at each of these stages planned in advance.
  - Not necessarily waterfall model – plan-driven, incremental development is possible
  - Iteration occurs within activities.
- Agile development
  - Specification, design, implementation and testing are inter-leaved and the outputs from the development process are decided through a process of negotiation during the software development process.

Plan-driven and agile specification



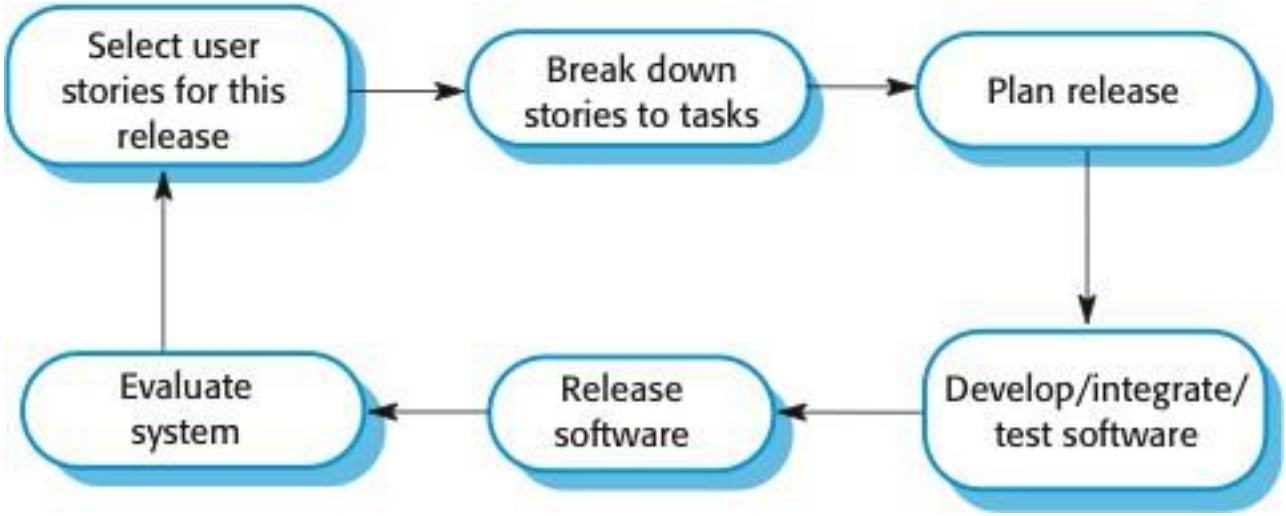
Extreme programming

- Perhaps the best-known and most widely used agile method.
- Extreme Programming (XP) takes an ‘extreme’ approach to iterative development.
  - New versions may be built several times per day;
  - Increments are delivered to customers every 2 weeks;
  - All tests must be run for every build and the build is only accepted if tests run successfully.

XP and agile principles

- Incremental development is supported through small, frequent system releases.
- Customer involvement means full-time customer engagement with the team.
- People not process through pair programming, collective ownership and a process that avoids long working hours.
- Change supported through regular system releases.
- Maintaining simplicity through constant refactoring of code.

The extreme programming releases cycle



Requirement’s scenarios

- In XP, a customer or user is part of the XP team and is responsible for making decisions on requirements.
- User requirements are expressed as scenarios or user stories.
- These are written on cards and the development team break them down into implementation tasks. These tasks are the basis of schedule and cost estimates.
- The customer chooses the stories for inclusion in the next release based on their priorities and the schedule estimates.

XP and change

- Conventional wisdom in software engineering is to design for change. It is worth spending time and effort anticipating changes as this reduces costs later in the life cycle.
- XP, however, maintains that this is not worthwhile as changes cannot be reliably anticipated.
- Rather, it proposes constant code improvement (refactoring) to make changes easier when they have to be implemented.

Refactoring

- Programming team look for possible software improvements and make these improvements even where there is no immediate need for them.
- This improves the understandability of the software and so reduces the need for documentation.
- Changes are easier to make because the code is well-structured and clear.
- However, some changes require architecture refactoring and this is much more expensive.

Examples of refactoring

- Re-organization of a class hierarchy to remove duplicate code.
- Tidying up and renaming attributes and methods to make them easier to understand.
- The replacement of inline code with calls to methods that have been included in a program library.

Testing in XP

- Testing is central to XP and XP has developed an approach where the program is tested after every change has been made.
- XP testing features:
  - Test-first development.
  - Incremental test development from scenarios.
  - User involvement in test development and validation.
  - Automated test harnesses are used to run all component tests each time that a new release is built.

Customer involvement

- The role of the customer in the testing process is to help develop acceptance tests for the stories that are to be implemented in the next release of the system.
- The customer who is part of the team writes tests as development proceeds. All new code is therefore validated to ensure that it is what the customer needs.
- However, people adopting the customer role have limited time available and so cannot work full-time with the development team. They may feel that providing the requirements was enough of a contribution and so may be reluctant to get involved in the testing process.

Test case description for dose checking

Test 4: Dose checking

Input:
1. A number in mg representing a single dose of the drug.
2. A number representing the number of single doses per day.

Tests:
1. Test for inputs where the single dose is correct but the frequency is too high.
2. Test for inputs where the single dose is too high and too low.
3. Test for inputs where the single dose * frequency is too high and too low.
4. Test for inputs where single dose * frequency is in the permitted range.

Output:
OK or error message indicating that the dose is outside the safe range.

XP testing difficulties

- Programmers prefer programming to testing and sometimes they take short cuts when writing tests. For example, they may write incomplete tests that do not check for all possible exceptions that may occur.
- Some tests can be very difficult to write incrementally. For example, in a complex user interface, it is often difficult to write unit tests for the code that implements the ‘display logic’ and workflow between screens.
- It difficult to judge the completeness of a set of tests. Although you may have a lot of system tests, your test set may not provide complete coverage.

Pair programming

- In XP, programmers work in pairs, sitting together to develop code.
- This helps develop common ownership of code and spreads knowledge across the team.
- It serves as an informal review process as each line of code is looked at by more than 1 person.
- It encourages refactoring as the whole team can benefit from this.
- Measurements suggest that development productivity with pair programming is similar to that of two people working independently.

Pair programming

- In pair programming, programmers sit together at the same workstation to develop the software.
- Pairs are created dynamically so that all team members work with each other during the development process.
- The sharing of knowledge that happens during pair programming is very important as it reduces the overall risks to a project when team members leave.
- Pair programming is not necessarily inefficient and there is evidence that a pair working together is more efficient than 2 programmers working separately.

Advantages of pair programming

- It supports the idea of collective ownership and responsibility for the system.
  - Individuals are not held responsible for problems with the code. Instead, the team has collective responsibility for resolving these problems.
- It acts as an informal review process because each line of code is looked at by at least two people.
- It helps support refactoring, which is a process of software improvement.
  - Where pair programming and collective ownership are used, others benefit immediately from the refactoring so they are likely to support the process.

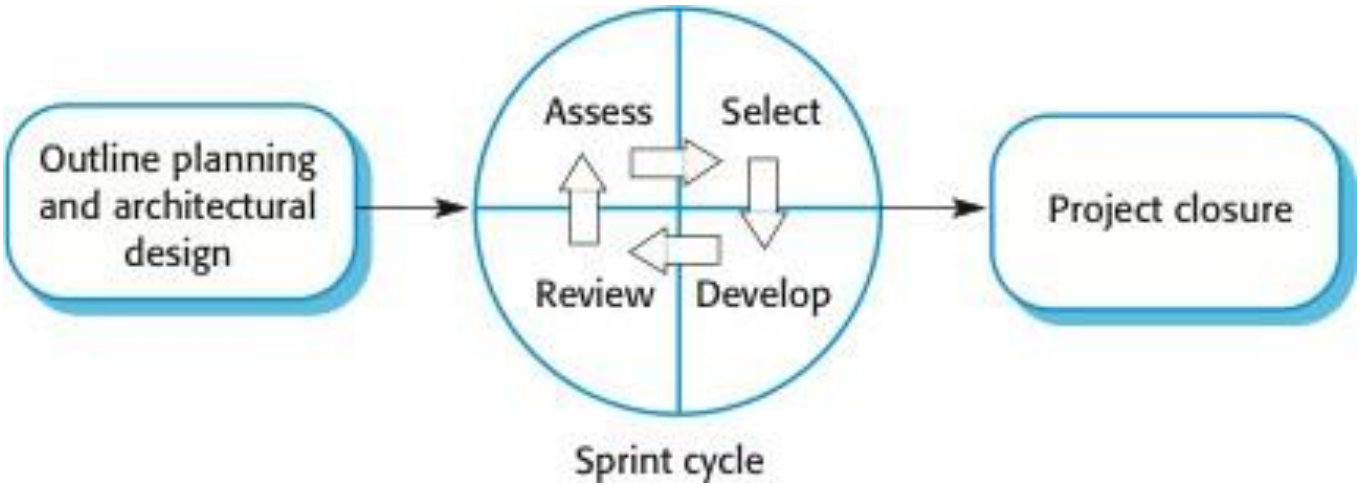
Agile project management

- The principal responsibility of software project managers is to manage the project so that the software is delivered on time and within the planned budget for the project.
- The standard approach to project management is plan-driven. Managers draw up a plan for the project showing what should be delivered, when it should be delivered and who will work on the development of the project deliverables.
- Agile project management requires a different approach, which is adapted to incremental development and the particular strengths of agile methods.

Scrum

- The Scrum approach is a general agile method but its focus is on managing iterative development rather than specific agile practices.
- There are three phases in Scrum.
  - The initial phase is an outline planning phase where you establish the general objectives for the project and design the software architecture.
  - This is followed by a series of sprint cycles, where each cycle develops an increment of the system.
  - The project closure phase wraps up the project, completes required documentation such as system help frames and user manuals and assesses the lessons learned from the project.
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The Scrum processes



The Sprint cycles

- Sprints are fixed length, normally 2–4 weeks. They correspond to the development of a release of the system in XP.
- The starting point for planning is the product backlog, which is the list of work to be done on the project.
- The selection phase involves all of the project team who work with the customer to select the features and functionality to be developed during the sprint.

The Sprint cycles

- Once these are agreed, the team organize themselves to develop the software. During this stage the team is isolated from the customer and the organization, with all communications channeled through the so-called ‘Scrum master’.
- The role of the Scrum master is to protect the development team from external distractions.
- At the end of the sprint, the work done is reviewed and presented to stakeholders. The next sprint cycle then begins.

Teamwork in Scrum

- The ‘Scrum master’ is a facilitator who arranges daily meetings, tracks the backlog of work to be done, records decisions, measures progress against the backlog and communicates with customers and management outside of the team.
- The whole team attends short daily meetings where all team members share information, describe their progress since the last meeting, problems that have arisen and what is planned for the following day.
  - This means that everyone on the team knows what is going on and, if problems arise, can re-plan short-term work to cope with them.

Scrum benefits

- The product is broken down into a set of manageable and understandable chunks.
- Unstable requirements do not hold up progress.
- The whole team have visibility of everything and consequently team communication is improved.
- Customers see on-time delivery of increments and gain feedback on how the product works.
- Trust between customers and developers is established and a positive culture is created in which everyone expects the project to succeed.

Scaling agile methods

- Agile methods have proved to be successful for small and medium sized projects that can be developed by a small co-located team.
- It is sometimes argued that the success of these methods comes because of improved communications which is possible when everyone is working together.
- Scaling up agile methods involves changing these to cope with larger, longer projects where there are multiple development teams, perhaps working in different locations.

Key points

- A particular strength of extreme programming is the development of automated tests before a program feature is created. All tests must successfully execute when an increment is integrated into a system.
- The Scrum method is an agile method that provides a project management framework. It is centered round a set of sprints, which are fixed time periods when a system increment is developed.
- Scaling agile methods for large systems is difficult. Large systems need up-front design and some documentation.